Literature: Fiction

H 1790

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A. Recent revisions

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

B. General rule

For collections of fiction, assign as many headings as necessary to bring out both the form and the topic(s), as outlined in sections C and D, below. For single works of fiction, assign headings to bring out topic(s) and form only as noted in section E, below. Optionally, assign form and topical headings to works of fiction, as outlined in section G, below.

Assign topical and form headings, especially to single works of fiction or to collections by one author, only as they come readily to mind after a superficial review of the work being cataloged.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Fiction***, ***Novels***, or ***Short stories***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Group Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***.

C. Designating the form of collections

C.1. General rule

Bring out the form of a collection by assigning headings of the type ***American fiction--20th century***; ***Short stories, American***; ***Epistolary fiction***; etc., as in the first heading in the following example.

Example:

```
Title: Garden tales : classic stories from favorite writers.
   650 #0 $a Short stories, American.
   650 #0 $a Gardens $v Fiction.
```

LC practice:

```
   650 #0 $a Short stories, American.
   650 #0 $a Gardens.
   655 #7 $a Short stories. $2 lcgft
```

Certain phrase headings combine both form and topical aspects into a single heading, for example, ***Detective and mystery stories, American***; ***Science fiction, American***; etc. These headings are used to designate both the form and the topic of collections, and no additional heading is usually required.

Do not use a phrase heading of this type if a more specific ***[topic]--Fiction*** heading can be formulated to designate the topic of the collection. Instead, assign the more specific heading in conjunction with a broader, non-topical, form heading.

LC practice: Do not use the form subdivision ***--Fiction***. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Fiction*** or ***Fantasy fiction***.

For example, assign the following headings to a collection of American stories about jungle warfare.

Example:

```
650 #0 $a American fiction.
650 #0 $a Jungle warfare $v Fiction.

[not 650 #0 $a War stories, American.]

[not 650 #0 $a War stories, American.
or 650 #0 $a Jungle warfare $v Fiction.]
```

LC practice:

650 #0 $a American fiction.

650 #0 $a Jungle warfare.

655 #7 $a War fiction. $2 lcgft

C.2. Collections of fiction by one author

As a general rule, assign form headings

a. if the form heading includes a topical aspect, for example, ***Western stories***, or
b. if it is readily apparent from a cursory examination of the work that it comprises fiction of a highly specific form and that this form is an essential point of the collection, for example, ***Allegories***; ***Fairy tales***; ***Radio stories***; ***Children's stories, English***; etc.

Do not assign nonspecific form headings to collections of fiction by one author, for example, ***American fiction***; ***Short stories, American***.

Do not attempt to assign a form heading to a collection of fiction by one author if the form is not stated on the title page or in another prominent location.

C.3. Collections of fiction for children

Assign the heading ***Children's stories*** or ***Children's stories, American, [English, etc.]*** to collections of fiction for children, whether by one author or several authors, in addition to the other required form and topical headings. Do not assign this heading to collections of fiction for young adults.

Example:

Title: Tales for the perfect child.

650 #0 $a Conduct of life $v Juvenile fiction.

650 #0 #a Children's stories, American.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Conduct of life.

650 #0 $a Children's stories, American.

655 #7 $a Short stories. $2 lcgft

385 ## $a Children $2 lcdgt

Example:

Title: Three sides of a heart : stories about love triangles.

[Intended audience: grades 9 and up]

650 #0 $a Romance fiction, American.

```
650 #0 #a Short stories, American.
```

LC practice:

```
650 #0 $a Romance fiction, American.
650 #0 $a Short stories, American.
655 #7 $a Romance fiction. $2 lcgft
655 #7 $a Short stories. $2 lcgft
385 ## $a Teenagers $2 lcdgt
```

D. Designating the topic(s) of collections by one or several authors

Bring out identifiable topics, using one of the types of headings listed in sections D.1-D.3, below.

Do not attempt to discern topics which have not been made explicit by the author or publisher, or which could be interpreted as representing value judgments.

D.1. [topic]--Fiction or [topic]--Juvenile fiction

Use headings of this type as the standard means of designating topics in fiction, for example, ***Slavery--United States--Fiction***; ***Parent and child--Fiction***; ***Horses--Fiction***; ***Paris (France)--Fiction***; ***Vodou--Fiction***.

Note: The subdivision ***--Stories***, which had formerly been used under some topics is no longer to be used. Use only ***--Fiction***.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Fiction*** or ***--Juvenile fiction*.** Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Fiction***, ***Short stories***, etc. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***, ***Teenagers***, etc.

Example:

```
Title: Galway stories.
650 #0 $a Short stories, Irish.
651 #0 $a Galway (Ireland) $v Fiction.
```

LC practice:

```
650 #0 $a Short stories, Irish.
651 #0 $a Galway (Ireland)
655 #7 $a Short stories. $2 lcgft
```

D.2. Phrase headings with topical aspects

If a phrase heading has both form and topical aspects, assign only the one heading to designate both form and topic, as described in section C.1., above. ***Sea stories***, ***Western stories***, and ***Romance fiction*** are examples of such headings.

Example:

Title: Bad company : stories of intrigue, suspense and thrills.

650 #0 $a Short stories, South African (English)

650 #0 $a Suspense fiction, South African (English)

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Short stories, South African (English)

650 #0 $a Suspense fiction, South African (English)

655 #7 $a Short stories. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Thrillers (Fiction) $2 lcgft

D.3. Individual characters

If the collection of fiction features as its theme an individual character or family, real or imaginary, bring out the character(s), for example, ***Lincoln, Abraham, 1809 1865--Fiction***; ***Holmes, Sherlock--Fiction***; ***Alcott family--Fiction***.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Fiction*** or ***--Juvenile fiction*.** Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Fiction*** or ***Short stories***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children*** or ***Teenagers***.

Example:

Title: The adventures of Father Brown.

600 10 $a Brown, $c Father (Fictitious character) $v Fiction.

650 #0 $a Priests $v Fiction.

650 #0 #a Detective and mystery stories, English.

LC practice:

600 10 $a Brown, $c Father (Fictitious character)

650 #0 $a Priests.

650 #0 #a Detective and mystery stories, English.

655 #7 $a Detective and mystery fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Short stories. $2 lcgft

E. Individual works of fiction

Note: This section describes standard practice followed at the Library of Congress for assigning subject headings to individual works of fiction. It includes instructions for LC catalogers no longer using form subdivisions as of early 2026. For an alternative approach to assigning subject headings to individual works of fiction, see section G at the end of this instruction sheet.

Assign no LCSH form headings to individual works of adult fiction, children's fiction, or young adult fiction.

Bring out topic(s) only for the following types of individual works of fiction:

E.1. Biographical fiction

Assign the heading ***[name of biographee]--Fiction***.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Fiction*** or ***--Juvenile fiction*.** Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Fiction*** or ***Short stories***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children*** or ***Teenagers***.

Example:

```
Title: The princess.
   600 00 $a Diana, $c Princess of Wales, $d 1961-1997 $v Fiction.
```

LC practice:

```
   600 00 $a Diana, $c Princess of Wales, $d 1961-1997.
   655 #7 $a Biographical fiction. $2 lcgft
   655 #7 $a Novels. $2 lcgft
```

E.2. Historical fiction

Assign headings for specific historical events, periods, etc., with the subdivision ***--Fiction***, e.g. ***World War, 1939 1945--Fiction***; ***San Francisco Earthquake and fire, Calif., 1906--Fiction***.

Do not assign a heading of this type when the event or period is merely the backdrop to a story. Assign it only when the event or period is the principal focus of the work.

Interpret the term ***historical fiction*** broadly to include works about entities such as movements, corporate bodies or other jurisdictions, camps, parks, structures, geographical features other than regions, ethnic groups, disasters, categories of events, etc.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Fiction*** or ***--Juvenile fiction*.** Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Fiction*** or ***Short stories***. To

replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children*** or ***Teenagers***.

Example:

```
Title: The shadow of war : a novel of the Cuban Missile Crisis.
   650 #0 $a Cuban Missile Crisis, 1962 $v Fiction.
```

LC practice:

```
   650 #0 $a Cuban Missile Crisis, 1962.
   655 #7 $a Historical fiction. $2 lcgft
   655 #7 $a Novels. $2 lcgft
```

E.3. Animal stories

Assign the heading ***Animals--Fiction*** to individual novels or stories about animals in general. For a work about a specific type of animal, assign a heading for the type of animal with the subdivision ***--Fiction***, e.g. ***Horses--Fiction***.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Fiction*** or ***--Juvenile fiction*.** Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Fiction*** or ***Short stories***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children*** or ***Teenagers***.

Example:

```
Title: Love, Clancy : diary of a good dog.
   650 #0 $a Dogs $v Fiction.
```

LC practice:

```
   650 #0 $a Dogs.
   655 #7 $a Animal fiction. $2 lcgft
   655 #7 $a Novels. $2 lcgft
```

F. History and criticism

F.1. General rule

For works about particular themes in fiction, assign as many headings as necessary to bring out the form (with subdivision ***--History and criticism***) and the topic(s) (normally using headings of the type ***[topic] in literature***).

Examples:

```
   650 #0 $a American fiction $y 20th century $x History and criticism.
```

```
650 #0 $a Politics in literature.
```

If a heading has both form and topical aspects, assign only the single heading with the subdivision ***--History and criticism***, for example, ***Detective and mystery stories, American--History and criticism***.

F.2. Fiction about individual persons or families

For criticism of fiction about particular individuals or families, including dynasties and royal houses, assign the name of the person or family with the free-floating topical subdivision ***--In literature***.

Examples:

```
600 10 $a Faust, $d -approximately 1540 $x In literature.
600 10 $a Shakespeare, William, $d 1564-1616 $x In literature.
600 30 $a Habsburg, House of $x In literature.
600 30 $a Mann family $x In literature.
```

F.3. Fiction about imaginary persons

For criticism of fiction about particular imaginary individuals, assign the name of the person. Also assign if appropriate for the work the name of the author with the subdivision ***--Characters*** (cf. H 1610).

Example:

```
600 10 $a Doyle, Arthur Conan, $c Sir, $d 1859-1930 $x Characters.
600 10 $a Holmes, Sherlock.
```

F.4. Fiction about individual corporate bodies, places, and sacred works

For criticism of fiction about particular corporate bodies, places, or sacred works, assign the name of the entity with the free-floating subdivision ***--In literature***.

Examples:

```
610 10 $a United States. $b Federal Bureau of Investigation $x In
       literature.
651 #0 $a Tahiti (French Polynesia : Island) $x In literature.
630 00 $a Bible $x In literature.
630 00 $a Qurʼan $x In literature.
```

F.5. Fiction about wars and similar events

For works about the fiction of a specific war, revolution, uprising, etc., assign ***[name of event]--Literature and the war, [revolution, uprising, etc.]*** as a topical heading (cf. H 1200).

Examples:

```
650 #00 $a World War, 1939-1945 $x Literature and the war.
651 #0 $a Algeria $x History $y Revolution, 1954-1962 $x Literature and the
      revolution.
```

F.6. Single works of fiction

For works about an individual novel or story in one of the categories of section E.1-E.3, above, assign a heading for the individual work as well as a heading for the theme.

Example:

```
600 10 $a Mitchell, Margaret, $d 1900-1949. $t Gone with the wind.
650 #0 $a United States $x History $y Civil War, 1861-1865 $x Literature and
      the war.
```

G. Special provisions for increased subject access to fiction

G.1. Application of special provisions

The Library of Congress applies special provisions for increased subject access to fiction as internal resources permit. As of January 2001 these provisions were being applied to cataloging for current acquisitions of American novels and novels of other English-language literatures. As of 2026, it is no longer LC practice to assign headings that include form subdivisions.

G.2. General principles

The assignment of subject headings to individual works of fiction is intended to provide the average public library user with an additional method of selecting recreational reading. Several types of subject headings are available to provide this access. Any, all, or none of the following categories of headings may be appropriate for an individual work of fiction: form/genre, character, setting, topic. These headings should be assigned only as they come readily to mind after a superficial review of the work being cataloged.

G.3. Form and genre headings

G.3.a. Source of headings

Select an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), for example, ***Biographical fiction***; ***Spy fiction***. Assign terms from LCGFT in accordance with the

instructions in J 235 of the LCGFT Manual. Headings from the second edition of the Guidelines on Subject Access to Individual Works of Fiction, Drama, Etc. (GSAFD) may be assigned instead, for example, ***Love stories***; ***Science fiction***.

If assigning headings from GSAFD, generally assign no more than one or two, expressing only the primary genre(s) of the work. Apply the same principle of specificity used in non-literary cataloging, e.g., ***Arthurian romances***, not ***Romances***; ***War stories***, not ***Historical fiction***.

Note: LC began to assign terms from LCGFT to fiction in English in 2021. Until then, GSFAD was used in LC bibliographic records. If an appropriate genre heading was not available from GSAFD, an unqualified form heading from LCSH was assigned in the MARC 655 field with second indicator 0. Broad LCSH headings such as ***Fiction*** were not assigned. Neither were headings that included adjectival qualifiers or subdivisions to show the language of the work or to reflect the characteristics of the author, such as nationality, religion, sex, or ethnic background.

G.3.b. MARC 21 content designation and input conventions

Form/genre headings for individual works use the MARC tag 655, not 650. For terms from LCGFT, the second indicator contains the value 7 and the code lcgft in a subfield $2 following the term. For headings from GSAFD, the second indicator contains the value 7 and the code gsafd in a subfield $2 following the heading. When assigned, these headings are input following other LC subject headings and following any Children's and Young Adult Cataloging (CYAC) subject headings.

Note: The second indicator value of 0 for LCSH was added to the 655 field in MARC 21 in 2003 and implemented at the Library of Congress in 2004. Records cataloged before 2004 indicate the source of headings from LCSH through the use of the second indicator value of 7 and the code lcsh in a subfield $2.

G.3.c. Updating of form/genre headings

LC will maintain the currency of form/genre headings for which the source is LCSH or LCGFT. Headings from GSAFD will be assigned from the most current edition available at the time of cataloging, but will not be updated if changes are made in later editions.

G.4. Character(s)

G.4.a. Individual characters

If the work prominently features a real person, a legendary character, or other major character not created by the author of the work, assign a subject heading for the name of the character with appropriate subdivision such as ***--Fiction*** or ***--Juvenile fiction***. If the primary character

is a fictitious character created by the author, assign a subject heading only if the character appears in three or more works. For instructions on establishing subject headings for fictitious characters see H 1610.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Fiction*** or ***--Juvenile fiction*.** Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Fiction*** or ***Short stories***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children*** or ***Teenagers***.

Note: Fictitious characters may be borrowed by an author from another author, or from another source, and used in the creation of a new work. Assign the same heading to works by the original creator of the character and to works in which the character has been borrowed.

Assign a separate heading when characters share a name but are clearly unrelated to each other.

G.4.b. Classes of persons

A heading may also be assigned for the class of persons to which the primary character belongs if that class of persons is established and is likely to be sought by the typical public library user, for example, women detectives. Generally follow the same principles that are used for selecting class-of-persons headings for individual biographies. Subdivide the heading with the appropriate subdivision such as ***--Fiction*** or ***--Juvenile fiction***.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Fiction*** or ***--Juvenile fiction*.** Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Fiction*** or ***Short stories***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children*** or ***Teenagers***.

G.5. Setting

Assign a subject heading for a place, event, or time period that is featured prominently in an individual work. Since almost all fictitious works have a specific place and time, assign these headings only if the place or time is significant. Generally do not assign headings for a time period that is contemporaneous to the period in which the work was written, for example, do not express the 19th-century setting of a work that was written in the 19th century. Assign a subject for an imaginary place or organization only if the place appears in three or more works. The place of the work may also be included as a subdivision of a topical heading, in accordance with normal subject cataloging practice, either in addition to a separate heading for place or as a substitute for a separate heading. Subdivide the heading with the appropriate subdivision such as ***--Fiction*** or ***--Juvenile fiction***.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Fiction*** or ***--Juvenile fiction*.** Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Fiction*** or ***Short stories***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children*** or ***Teenagers***.

G.6. Topical access

Assign headings for specific topics that are the focal point of an individual literary work. Assign headings only for topics that have been made explicit by the author or publisher, such as those topics that are mentioned in the title, series, introductory matter, dustjacket, or other prominent location. The purpose of the topical heading is to provide access for those topics that distinguish the work from most other works. Do not assign headings for vague and general topics, such as fate, evil, belief, psychology, interpersonal relations, emotions, social customs, or community life. The same principle of specificity should be applied as is used in non-literary cataloging. Do not assign both a broader and more specific heading to the same work; assign only the most specific heading that is appropriate. Normally no more than one or two topical headings should be assigned. Many works will have no topical heading. Subdivide the heading with the appropriate subdivision such as ***--Fiction*** or ***--Juvenile fiction***.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Fiction*** or ***--Juvenile fiction*.** Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Fiction*** or ***Short stories***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children*** or ***Teenagers***.

H. Examples

Title: Yankee warrior : the story of a Civil War hero from Maine.

600 10 $a Morrill, Walter Goodale, $d 1840-1935 $v Fiction.

651 #0 $a United States $x History $y Civil War, 1861-1865 $v Fiction.

655 #7 $a Biographical fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a War fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Novels. $2 lcgft

LC practice:

600 10 $a Morrill, Walter Goodale, $d 1840-1935.

651 #0 $a United States $x History $y Civil War, 1861-1865.

655 #7 $a Biographical fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a War fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Novels. $2 lcgft

Title: The red horseman.

600 10 $a Grafton, Jake $v Fiction.

650 #0 $a Nuclear weapons plants $v Fiction.

650 #0 $a Terrorism $v Fiction.

651 #0 $a Russia (Federation) $v Fiction.

655 #7 $a Spy fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Novels. $2 lcgft

LC practice:

600 10 $a Grafton, Jake.

650 #0 $a Nuclear weapons plants.

650 #0 $a Terrorism.

651 #0 $a Russia (Federation)

655 #7 $a Spy fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Novels. $2 lcgft

Title: I, Richard : stories of suspense.

655 #7 $a Detective and mystery fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Short stories. $2 lcgft

Title: First degree love : a novel of euthanasia.

650 #0 $a Euthanasia $v Fiction.

651 #0 $a Kentucky $v Fiction.

655 #7 $a Medical fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Novels. $2 lcgft

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Euthanasia.

651 #0 $a Kentucky.

655 #7 $a Medical fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Novels. $2 lcgft

Title: The French consul.

650 #0 $a Consuls $z China $v Fiction.

651 #0 $a China $x History $y Warlord period, 1916-1928 $v Fiction.

655 #7 $a Historical fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Political fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Novels. $2 lcgft

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Consuls $z China.

651 #0 $a China $x History $y Warlord period, 1916-1928.

655 #7 $a Historical fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Political fiction. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Novels. $2 lcgft

Title: The story of Rolf and the Viking bow.

651 #0 $a Iceland $x History $y To 1262 $v Juvenile fiction.

650 #0 $a Vikings $v Juvenile fiction.

650 #0 $a Adventure and adventurers $v Juvenile fiction.

650 #0 $a Middle Ages $v Juvenile fiction.

655 #7 $a Historical fiction. $2 lcgft

LC practice:

651 #0 $a Iceland $x History $y To 1262.

650 #0 $a Vikings.

650 #0 $a Adventure and adventurers.

650 #0 $a Middle Ages.

655 #7 $a Historical fiction. $2 lcgft

385 ## $a Children $2 lcdgt

Revision history

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.